

Donation money, temple items allegedly stolen in Bogura

Police investigating theft; no formal complaint filed yet

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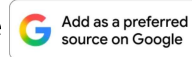
Our Correspondent, Bogura



Money from a donation box and various items were allegedly stolen from a Kali temple in Matihass village under Nandigram upazila of Bogura.

An idol from the temple was later found abandoned at a nearby pond.

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Temple authorities said the incident occurred between Thursday evening and Friday morning.

The temple's priest, Shri Khagendranath Pramanik, told local journalists that he left after completing the puja rituals on Thursday evening. When he returned on Friday morning, he found the donation box broken and the idol of Sannyasi Thakur missing.



Brass items, including a bell, trident, gong and plates, were also stolen, temple authorities said.

The idol was later recovered from a nearby pond, the priest said.

Tarikul Islam, officer-in-charge of Nandigram Police Station, told The Daily Star that police conducted a preliminary inquiry after receiving the news.

He said local residents had seen the idol lying in a field near the temple on Thursday morning, adding that it remained unclear whether it had been taken there for ritual immersion.

“Furthermore, the temple remains open and unenclosed. We know that some ritual items and brass utensils were missing. Police are investigating to identify those involved,” he said.

The temple authorities have not yet filed a written complaint. “Necessary legal action will be taken once a formal complaint is received,” the OC added.



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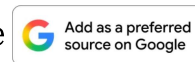


Representational image. File photo

More than half of the anthrax cases reported in Meherpur's Gangni upazila so far this year have been linked to coming into contact with goat meat, according to health officials.

According to Gangni Upazila Health Complex, Gangni has been an anthrax hotspot in the country for more than a decade, with the health complex recording 412 cases as of September 20 this year.

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The health complex recorded 608 cases last year, according to the district civil surgeon's office.

According to data compiled from the health complex, 262 people, or around 62 percent of the 412 anthrax patients, contracted the disease through contact with mutton (goat meat). Besides, 130 people contracted the disease from beef, while 20 contracted the disease for unidentified reasons.

Confirming the data, Meherpur Civil Surgeon Dr AKM Abu Sayed told this correspondent that, "I also have the list. We have also noticed that most affected people contracted the disease through contact with goat meat."

He also said that among the district's three upazilas, the infection rate in Gangni was particularly alarming. The figure of 412 infections in the upazila is likely the highest recorded so far.

Abdul Hannan, health inspector at Gangni Upazila Health Complex, said that the list of 412 individuals was prepared by their team. Officials from the Institute of Epidemiology, Disease Control and Research (IEDCR) were also involved in the exercise.

He also confirmed that a higher number of people were affected after contact with goat meat.

Dr Arif, one of the three-member IEDCR team researching anthrax at Gangni Upazila Health Complex, said they had also observed a higher rate of transmission linked to goats.

However, he said the upazila health officer would be better placed to explain how transmission rates differ across sources.

Abdul Hannan said the higher transmission linked to goats could be due to greater human contact with the animals in rural areas.

"Goats are also slaughtered more frequently than other livestock, which may increase the risk of transmission," he said.

Masudur Rahman, resident medical officer of the health complex, told The Daily Star that the 412 cases recorded in the first nine months of this year were higher than in any corresponding period in recent years.

On September 14, Sofela Khatun, 35, of Nowdammotmura village under Motmura Union, sought treatment at the health complex after contracting anthrax.

Talking to this correspondent, she said her husband had bought goat meat from Bamundi Bazar in the upazila. She washed and cleaned the meat. Later, her daughter cooked it, and the entire family ate it. However, she was the only member of the family to contract anthrax.

Sofela said, "I went to the doctor after blisters appeared on the fingers of my right hand and I felt a burning sensation. They diagnosed anthrax and provided treatment. I have been asked to return this week. The condition has improved considerably."

RMO Masudur also said patients are treated in two stages at the health complex. They receive follow-up treatment one week after their initial visit. Most patients recover within two weeks.

However, despite the high infection rate linked to goat meat, goats are generally not vaccinated against anthrax.

According to data from the district livestock office, the district has a total livestock population of 1,074,400, including 373,000 cattle, 1,400 buffaloes, 671,000 goats, and 29,000 sheep.

Dr Md Toffazzal Hossain, Meherpur district livestock officer, told The Daily Star that more than 40,000 cattle and buffaloes had been vaccinated against anthrax so far this year.



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"However, we do not vaccinate goats. As goats are sensitive animals, they develop side effects in many cases," he said.

He said the prescribed dose for cattle and buffaloes is 1 ml. Although goats are supposed to receive a dose of 0.5 ml or 0.25 ml, they often cannot tolerate it.

"When goats die following vaccination, farmers hold livestock officials responsible. For this reason, goats are not vaccinated," Toffazzal claimed.

Preliminary observations by health authorities suggest that a significant proportion of those infected may have contracted the disease while slaughtering, cutting, handling, or processing meat from infected cattle and goats.

Although the sale and purchase of meat have declined somewhat amid fears of anthrax in the upazila, there was little evidence of public awareness.

During a visit to Gangni Bazar on September 26, The Daily Star found three traders selling meat from animals slaughtered that morning.

Jahangir, who has been selling meat there for 38 years, claimed that doctors from the municipality came every morning to examine the health of animals before slaughter.

However, Gangni Upazila Nirbahi Officer Rashed Hossain said the meat seller's claim was untrue. "It would be good if that were possible. But not all of their claims are true," he said.

"The way anthrax has spread is alarming. We have sufficient vaccines and have begun taking preventive measures. We have also instructed that infected animals must not be brought to markets. If anyone is found selling meat from such animals, legal action will be taken," the UNO added,

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Three arrested, including a couple

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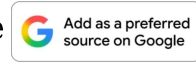
Our Correspondent, Barishal



A 35-year-old man who went missing after receiving a phone call asking him to visit a house in Bhola's Charfesson yesterday was found dead in a pond today, with marks around his neck and his abdomen cut open.

The deceased was identified as Bashar Pandit of Nazrul Nagar union in the upazila.

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According to eyewitnesses, a local woman, Salma, called Bashar to her house around 11:00am yesterday, after which he went missing.

Police said Bashar's body was recovered around noon today from a water hyacinth-covered pond in front of Salma's house.

As the news spread, angry locals vandalised Salma's house before setting it on fire.

On information, firefighters from Charfesson rushed to the site and brought the blaze under control.

Meanwhile, police arrested three people, including Salma and her husband Saidur Rahman, in connection with the incident.

Additional Superintendent of Police Ahsanuzzaman said they have visited the site after receiving the news.

"Those arrested were all close to the deceased and had financial dealings with him," he said.

“We are investigating the motive behind the killing and identifying everyone involved. However, Saidur has initially confessed to killing Bashar over a financial dispute and out of a desire for revenge,” he added.

Bashar’s father, Abul Kashem, said, “I demand a thorough investigation into the incident and swift justice, with exemplary punishment for those responsible.”



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